

▶ **WHEN NAMRATA VARDAM** was researching career paths after her BSc in Zoology, followed by an MBA, she picked hospitality sales. But selling hotel rooms and banquets left her hungry. She switched to pharmaceutical sales. Today, Vardam, 33, is a product executive at Entod Pharma, a specialist in ophthalmic and ENT medicines, but has switched from sales to marketing. She is happy with her choice: she has a meaningful role in connecting science with people. “I’m fascinated by the blend of science and communication. The pharma industry offers a chance to make complex science understandable to a wider audience,” says Vardam.

Healthcare and pharmaceuticals are being transformed by the entry of women at all levels—women who are creating a new era of inclusivity and diversity.

Possibly more than any other sector, India’s healthcare and pharma have been known for a few decades now for women at the top, whether they were joining the family business (Sangita Reddy and her three sisters at Apollo Hospitals) or creating a world-class business (Kiran Mazumdar-Shaw of Biocon).

More women are getting boardroom seats, as consultancy EY says in its October 2022 report ‘Diversity

in the Boardroom: Progress and the Way Forward’. The EY report says India has made substantial progress, with women accounting for an average of 18 per cent of board seats in 2022, up from just 6 per cent in 2013.

This number, based on companies in the BSE 200 index, puts India among those with less than 25 per cent, such as Singapore (24.1 per cent), Brazil (18.2 per cent), Hong Kong (17.9 per cent), and Japan (14.7 per cent).

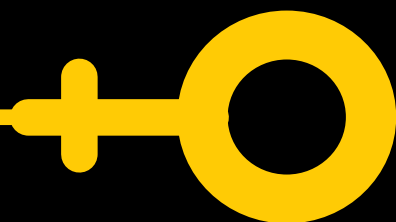
In India, the life sciences sector took the lead, with women holding 24 per cent of board seats in October 2022, followed by the media & entertainment sector.

THE BECKONING

Today’s educational landscape offers more opportunities for women in areas such as medicine and pharmacy. And not just in entry- or mid-level jobs: more women are getting into boardrooms at pharma and healthcare companies. While some get board seats by inheriting a business, others are gunning for management jobs.

Why are so many women getting into the healthcare and pharma industry? Is it driven by a personal calling, societal dynamics, or the sector’s unique opportunities?

Meenakshi Nevatia, Country President & Managing



BOOSTER DOSE

The rise in the number of women in the workforce of India’s healthcare and pharmaceutical sectors can be attributed to:

TRADITIONAL ROLES

Women have always been the backbone of care-

giving, making healthcare a perfect fit for them. Their staunch determination and passion help

them to address critical healthcare issues and create innovative solutions

INCREASED EDUCATIONAL QUALIFICATIONS

Female students have started to outnumber males in Indian medical schools, indicating a positive trend for gender diversity in medical education

JOB STABILITY

The prevalence

of steady career opportunities makes the pharma and healthcare sectors attractive for women

GOVERNMENT INITIATIVES

Policies such as Pradhan Mantri Kaushal Vikas Yojana help bring more women into the labour force, while regulations like the Maternity Benefit Act encourage their participation and equal opportunities in healthcare